Conveyor Jam Clearing Safety Procedure

Purpose and Scope

This procedure governs how operators and maintenance personnel clear product or container jams on conveyors C1 through C4 and the infeed and outfeed sections of the filler and capper at Riverbend Packaging. Jam clearing is one of the most frequent causes of hand and finger injuries in packaging plants because the task is routine, urgent, and performed close to moving parts.

Core Rule

WARNING: No part of the body may enter the guarded zone of a conveyor, including a hand, arm, or tool held by hand, until the conveyor has been fully locked out under the Lockout/Tagout Procedure. This applies to ALL jams regardless of size, and regardless of how briefly the hand will be inside. Jog mode, reduced speed, E-stop, and pause buttons are not acceptable substitutes for lockout.

Guarded zones include any area behind a fixed guard, any area behind an interlocked gate, and any area within 12 inches of an exposed nip point, roller, sprocket, or chain.

Before You Begin

1. Stop the line using the normal stop and inform the line lead.
2. Identify the jam location and the equipment upstream and downstream that may be affected.
3. Put on required PPE: safety glasses and cut-resistant gloves (A4). Remove gloves if working near exposed rotating shafts.
4. Gather tools. Use a plastic or wooden jam hook for removing product; never use a screwdriver or bare hand.

Clearing Procedure

1. Perform full lockout on the conveyor disconnect (see the Energy Source Inventory in the LOTO Procedure). Apply your personal lock and tag.
2. Release stored energy. Conveyors on inclines can roll back due to gravity; block the belt or chain with a wedge before reaching in.
3. Verify isolation by pressing the local start button and confirming no movement.
4. Remove the jammed product. Work from the side, never reach over a moving or potentially moving section.
5. Inspect for damaged belts, guides, or sprockets, and report anything bent or cracked to maintenance.
6. Remove tools and confirm that no debris remains in the guarded zone.
7. Replace all guards and close all interlocked gates.
8. Remove your lock and tag, clear personnel, and restart following the restoration steps in the LOTO Procedure.

Jam Types and Hazards

Jam type	Typical cause	Primary hazard	Required control
Fallen bottle at transfer	Misaligned guide rail	Pinch at transfer plate	Full LOTO
Cap pile-up at capper infeed	Chute obstruction	Entanglement near star wheel	Full LOTO
Case jam at outfeed	Over-tall stack	Crush between case and frame	Full LOTO, block incline
Debris on return belt	Broken glass or label	Laceration	Full LOTO, cut gloves
Chain stall under load	Overload or seized idler	Stored tension	Full LOTO, release tension

Prohibited Practices

- Clearing jams with the conveyor running or in jog mode.
- Reaching over or under guards.
- Bypassing, taping, or defeating an interlock switch.
- Using the E-stop as the only means of isolation.
- Allowing a second person to restart equipment while someone is inside the guarded zone.

Glass Breakage

If a glass container breaks on the conveyor, stop the line and lock out before cleanup. Use a brush and dustpan or a vacuum rated for glass. Do not use bare hands. Dispose of fragments in the labeled sharps container. Product lots that passed through the breakage area must be placed on quality hold per the Nonconformance and Hold Procedure.

Contractor and Visitor Rules

Contractors working on conveyors must follow this procedure and apply their own locks. Visitors may not enter guarded zones.

Incident Reporting

Report all injuries, including minor cuts, and near misses to your supervisor immediately. The EHS Lead investigates any incident involving a guarded zone entry without lockout and may issue disciplinary action or retraining. A lock-out violation is treated as a serious safety rule violation.

Training and Verification

All operators complete jam-clearing training annually. Supervisors observe jam clearing during walk-throughs and correct deviations immediately. Quarterly audits sample at least five jam events and confirm that lockout was applied.